

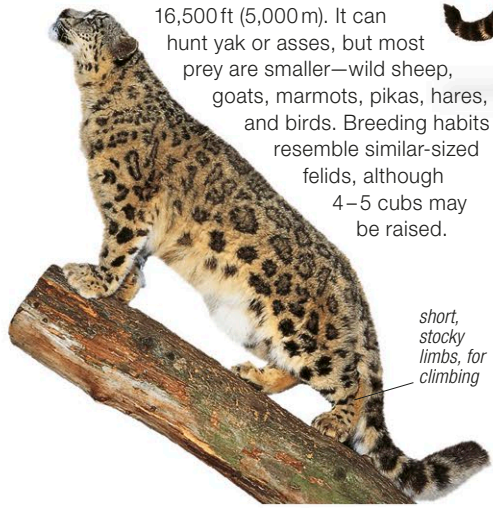
Panthera uncia

Snow leopard



Length 2¾–4¼ ft (0.9–1.25 m)
Tail 32–39 in (80–100 cm)
Weight 49–115 lb (22–52 kg)
Location C., S., and E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered

Resembling the leopard (see p.206) in its wide range of prey, this woolly furred big cat prefers crags and ridges in steppe, rocky shrub, and open conifer forest to altitudes of 16,500 ft (5,000 m). It can hunt yak or asses, but most prey are smaller—wild sheep, goats, marmots, pikas, hares, and birds. Breeding habits resemble similar-sized felids, although 4–5 cubs may be raised.



Panthera onca

Jaguar



Length 4–5½ ft (1.2–1.7 m)
Tail 17½–32 in (44–80 cm)
Weight 71–260 lb (31–121 kg)
Location Central America to N. and C. South America
Social unit Individual
Status Near threatened



The New World's only "big" cat, the jaguar resembles the leopard (see p.206) but has rosettes with dark centers, and is more squat and powerful, with a large, broad head and heavily muscled quarters. It prefers a watery environment, such as permanent swamps and seasonally flooded forest, where its main prey are medium-sized mammals such as deer, peccaries, and tapirs. Despite legal protection and reduced hunting for fur, jaguars are increasingly at risk from habitat destruction and their elimination from cattle ranches.

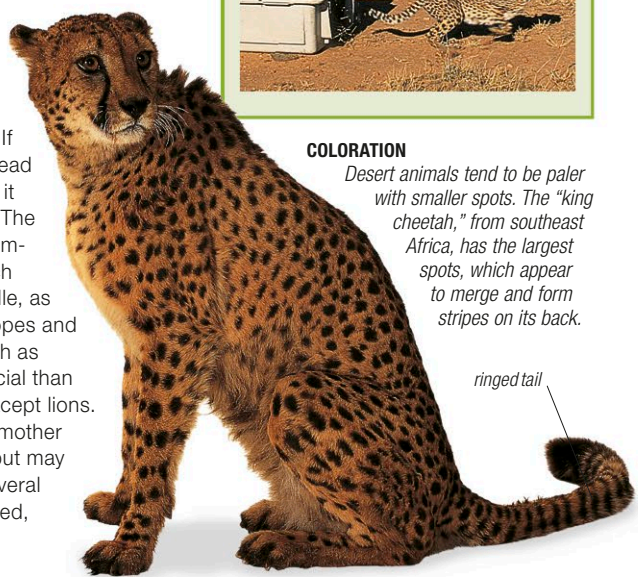
Acinonyx jubatus

Cheetah



Length 3½–5 ft (1.1–1.5 m)
Tail 23½–32 in (60–80 cm)
Weight 79–130 lb (36–59 kg)
Location Africa, W. Asia
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Vulnerable

Renowned as the world's fastest land animal, the cheetah can sprint at over 62 mph (100 kph) for 10–20 seconds, before it begins to overheat. If its prey can stay ahead for longer than this, it invariably escapes. The cheetah eats medium-sized ungulates such as Thomson's gazelle, as well as larger antelopes and smaller animals such as hares. It is more social than any other big cat except lions. Siblings leave their mother at 13–20 months, but may stay together for several more months—indeed, brothers may stay together for years.



CONSERVATION

In Namibia, in order to monitor the effect of wildlife management and livestock protection measures, some cheetahs are caught and fit with radio collars. Following their release (below), the animal's movements are tracked.



COLORATION

Desert animals tend to be paler with smaller spots. The "king cheetah," from southeast Africa, has the largest spots, which appear to merge and form stripes on its back.

Panthera leo

Lion

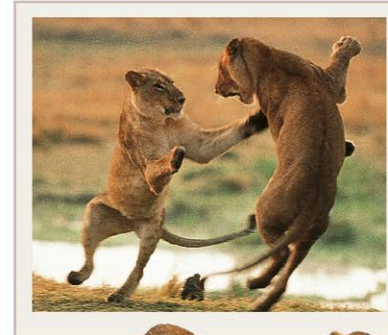


Length 5¼–8¼ ft (1.6–2.5 m)
Tail 24–39 ft (61–100 cm)
Weight 280–550 lb (125–250 kg)
Location Africa, S. Asia (Gir Forest)
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable

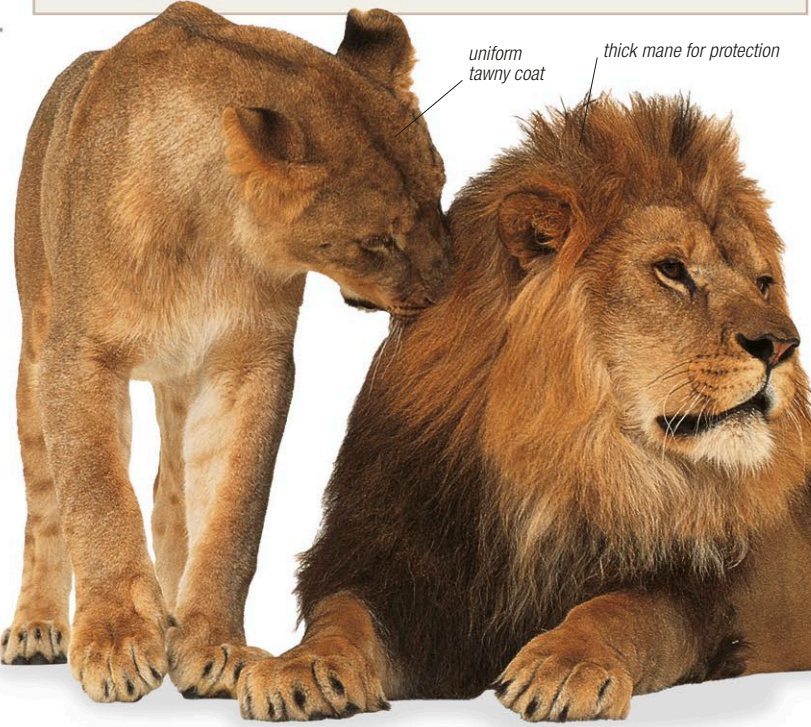
Unique among felids, lions form close-knit, long-term social groups. In females, these are called prides, and average 4–6 related adults and their cubs. Females tend to give birth at the same time and suckle each other's young. Prides occupy home ranges and members cooperate to hunt large prey such as zebra, wildebeest, impala, and buffalo. Individuals also forage alone for small rodents, hares, and reptiles. Adult males live alone, or in coalitions of usually 2–3 unrelated members or 4–5 relatives (originating from the same pride). A coalition defends a large area against other male coalitions, and holds mating rights over prides within it, but this tenure generally lasts only 2–3 years.

MALE AND FEMALE
The lion averages 400 lb (180 kg) against the lioness's 280 lb (125 kg). The male's skull is also significantly larger than that of the female.

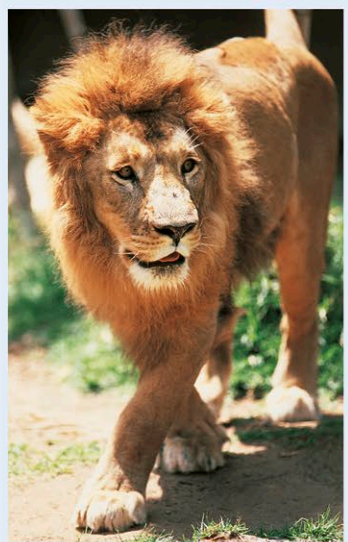
ROLE PLAYING



Retracted claws and nonexposed teeth show that these 2-year-old lionesses are "play-fighting" to develop skills for the hunt. The tussle helps to determine whether a lioness will be one of those who chase and direct prey—or one who carries out the ambush and kill. Play also helps to establish relative social status within the pride.



ASIATIC LION



The Asiatic lion (*Panthera leo persica*) survives only in the Gir Forest region of northwest India, with a probable population of about 350. It tends to be smaller than the African lion, with a fold of skin along the central underside of the belly; males have shorter manes. Prides are also smaller, usually 2 related females and young.